

# The Washington Post

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## CDC pick promoted false theory on vaccines

Embrace of disproven link between autism, shots alarms experts

BY LENA H. SUN, FENIT NIRAPPIL AND AARON SCHAFER

The world's most respected infectious-disease agency needed a new leader. Anti-vaccine activists knew just the man: Dave Weldon, a Florida physician and former seven-term Republican congressman who had for years expressed concerns about the safety of vaccines.

The year was 2017. Weldon didn't get the job then, but, seven years later, President-elect Donald Trump has tapped the 71-year-old former Army doctor to run the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The CDC is charged with protecting the United States from health threats at home and abroad. That includes making vaccine recommendations — work that has come under fire from Robert F. Kennedy Jr., the longtime vaccine skeptic whom Trump has picked to lead the Department of Health and Human Services, which has oversight over the CDC.

Kennedy proposed Weldon for the job, according to a person involved in the process who spoke on the condition of anonymity to share a private conversation.

Weldon's past record of promoting the disproven link between vaccines and autism in the face of overwhelming scientific evidence attesting to the safety and efficacy of vaccines raises concerns among some public

SEE WELDON ON A4

## Celebrating 25 years of snowflakes and sugar plum fairies



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

A dancer watches from backstage as Metropolitan School of the Arts performs “The Nutcracker” on Sunday at the Rachel M. Schlesinger Concert Hall and Arts Center in Alexandria. This year marked the art school's 25th annual production of the piece, with a cast consisting of 150 students.

## Slain CEO had worried about company's image

BY ANNIE GOWEN, DAN DIAMOND AND YEGANEH TORBATT

In early 2024, UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson had an urgent warning for his colleagues: The company has a public relations problem.

Average Americans didn't understand the massive insurance company's role in the nation's

health system, Thompson argued in internal discussions and with fellow executives, including steps it had taken to eliminate out-of-pocket costs for lifesaving drugs, colleagues said. Instead, UnitedHealthcare and its parent, UnitedHealth Group, faced investigations, a congressional probe and simmering consumer anger over charges it was making billions by denying health care to the ill and

the elderly.

“He understood that the public was frustrated with what they perceived the company's actions to be,” according to one person who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private business conversations. “He was actively articulating a vision that helped better educate and help people better understand what the company is doing.”

Anger directed at the company played a role on Dec. 4, authorities said, when 26-year-old Ivy League graduate Luigi Mangione allegedly shot and killed the executive in Midtown Manhattan as Thompson was on his way into UnitedHealth's annual investor conference. Police have said Mangione was motivated by animus toward America's health-care

SEE THOMPSON ON A2

## Musk sees his wealth soar after the election

Trump's promise to cut regulations could further boost billionaire's empire

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI AND TRISHA THADANI

Elon Musk's net worth has climbed by more than \$200 billion in 2024, a massive increase in the same year that the world's richest person spent at least \$277 million backing Donald Trump and other Republican candidates.

The bulk of the increase, more than \$170 billion, has come since Election Day.

Trump's election sent stock in electric-vehicle maker Tesla, a company central to Musk's wealth and where he is CEO, soaring. Shares were trading at prices about 70 percent higher on Friday than on Election Day.

As of Friday, Musk's fortune was about \$442 billion, according to the Bloomberg Billionaires Index. That estimate includes a pay

SEE MUSK ON A7

**Inseparable:** Musk is a near constant at Trump's side. A7



ANNIE O'NEILL FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

**HOLA Ohio Executive Director Veronica Isabel Dahlberg at the organization's Christmas party. HOLA Ohio is a nonprofit that advocates for Latino workers and families.**

## In Ohio, an immigrant community prepares for Trump's crackdown

BY JOANNA SLATER

PAINESVILLE, OHIO — Veronica Isabel Dahlberg looked out at dozens of familiar faces gathered in a new community center on a recent Monday evening, all of them anxious for answers she didn't have.

What would happen to the immigrants and farmworkers in this swath of northeastern Ohio? Dahlberg, who has worked with the community for nearly three decades, couldn't say whether

President-elect Donald Trump would follow through on his pledge to carry out mass deportations. But she reminded the audience what his first term looked like here.

The ramped-up deportations, not of “bad guys” or criminals, but mothers and fathers pulled over for routine traffic stops. The people so frightened of being detained they sought sanctuary in local churches. The raids on a flower nursery and meat processing plant in the

SEE OHIO ON A6

## Turkey exploits ‘war on terror’ to go after exiles

It targets critics in Gulen movement by drawing on post-9/11 playbook

BY GREG MILLER

ANKARA, TURKEY — As abduction teams fanned out across neighborhoods in Nairobi in October, their targets — members of a Turkish religious movement — seemed to have few worries beyond the hassles of a hectic week-day.

One was returning from a visa appointment with his family; a second was at the motor vehicle office for a driving test; still others were trying to beat traffic during the early Friday commute.

By morning's end, seven Turkish nationals had been abducted at gunpoint, hooded and handcuffed by masked agents traveling in unmarked vehicles, according to Western security officials, witnesses and relatives of the victims. While three were later released, four were taken to a remote airstrip outside the Kenyan capital, officials said, and forced aboard a plane waiting to take them to a Turkish prison near here.

The abductions were the latest of more than 118 “renditions” that Turkey's intelligence service, MIT, has orchestrated over the

past decade, according to the spy agency's website, making it one of the most aggressive practitioners of such extralegal operations. In Nairobi, MIT relied on Kenyan government operatives to carry out the abductions and was able to bypass Kenyan courts, according to the Western security officials who, like others, spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss a sensitive operation.

Turkey has branded this global campaign its own “war on terror” in an echo of the phrase that came to define the period after the Sept. 11, 2001, attacks in the United States. Turkey has also drawn extensively from the U.S. counterterrorism playbook. Beyond renditions, it has used secret detentions, terrorism watch lists, asset seizures and torture — including at least one reported case of waterboarding — against exiles, according to U.N. documents, human rights groups, Western security officials and public records in Turkey.

These operations have been “justified in the name of combating terrorism,” according to a U.N. report, even though nearly all those targeted are members of a religious sect known as the Gulen movement with no history of terrorist attacks. Turkey has labeled the group a terrorist organization because of its members' alleged involvement in a failed 2016 coup. But the United

SEE TURKEY ON A11

## IN THE NEWS

**Drones over Kyiv** A searchlight, a World War II-era machine gun and lots of caffeine help a band of volunteers protect the night skies above Ukraine's capital. A8

**ABC News settles** The network will pay \$15 million in a defamation case brought by Donald Trump over an anchor's remarks. C1

**THE NATION**  
**As President** Joe Biden touts his legacy, his frustrations have sometimes seeped through. A3  
**House Democrats** are pushing for the publication of the Equal Rights Amendment. A4

**THE WORLD**  
**The fall of** Yoon Suk Yeol, a political outsider turned president of South Korea, was as fast as his rise. A9  
**This year's** Spanish Scrabble champion can't speak the language. A12

**THE ECONOMY**  
**Women have** exerted historic levels of influence over technology policy in the past four years, but many will soon lose power. A13

**THE REGION**  
**Two local** World War II veterans recall their parts in the Battle of the Bulge 80 years ago. B1

**Cybersecurity experts** warn that scammers are using AI to impersonate real estate agents, lenders or other parties in a home sale. B1  
**Food delivery** companies are pushing back on a D.C. bill that, among other regulations, would require data sharing and the display of logos. B1

**STYLE**  
**The first flagship** store for Kim Kardashian's shapewear line, Skims, is a temple to curves in the heart of New York. C1  
**A woman** who accused Sean “Diddy” Combs and Jay-Z of raping her when she was 13 admitted to inconsistencies in her account in an interview. C1

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